

UNIT III - COMPREHENSION (SEEN AND UNSEEN PASSAGES)

Communication Skills (English) — Course Code
311303

Overview

Comprehension means **understanding, analyzing, and responding to a written passage** accurately. This unit builds the ability to read a passage carefully, grasp its central idea and details, and answer questions based on it — both in written and spoken form. It is directly aligned with **CO3: “Comprehend passages correctly.”**

3.1 PASSAGES FROM MSBTE WORKBOOK (SEEN PASSAGES)

Your syllabus lists six prescribed passages to be studied from the MSBTE workbook:

1. **Say No to Plastic Bags** — an awareness-based passage on environmental pollution caused by plastic and the need for sustainable alternatives.
2. **Interview of Dr. APJ Abdul Kalam** — an interview-format passage highlighting his views, vision, and values as a scientist and educator.
3. **Maximum Achievements** — a motivational passage likely focused on goal-setting, hard work, and success.
4. **Be Remarkable** — an inspirational passage encouraging individuality, excellence, and standing out through positive action.
5. **Arunima Sinha: A Biography** — the life story of the first female amputee to climb Mount Everest, focused on courage and perseverance.
6. **Roses of Gratitude** — a passage likely centered on the theme of thankfulness and appreciation in life.

Note: As these are copyrighted passages from the official MSBTE workbook, I can't reproduce their text here. Please refer to your MSBTE workbook/Spectrum book for the original passages. I can, however, help you a lot with **how to study them** — see the strategy below — and I'm happy to help you practice answering comprehension questions on any of these if you paste the passage text or your own summary.

How to Study These “Seen” Passages Effectively

Since these are known in advance, your goal is **mastery**, not just a first read:

1. **First read** - read for overall meaning (don't stop at unknown words)
2. **Second read** - identify the theme, tone, and purpose of each paragraph
3. **Note key facts** - names, dates, events, statistics mentioned
4. **Identify difficult vocabulary** - note new words, their meaning in

context

5. **Anticipate questions** – prepare answers for: main idea, character/author’s viewpoint, moral/message, vocabulary-in-context questions
 6. **Practice summarizing** – write a 5-6 line summary of each passage in your own words
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3.2 IMPORTANCE OF COMPREHENSION

Comprehension is a foundational skill because it underlies almost all academic and professional communication.

Why Comprehension Skills Matter

1. **Academic Success** – Understanding textbooks, exam questions, and technical manuals depends on strong comprehension.
2. **Workplace Communication** – Engineers and professionals must correctly interpret reports, instructions, emails, and specifications; misreading can lead to costly errors.
3. **Critical Thinking** – Comprehension isn’t just decoding words; it involves **analyzing, inferring, and evaluating** the writer’s intent and argument.
4. **Vocabulary Building** – Reading varied passages exposes you to new words, expressions, and sentence structures, expanding active vocabulary.
5. **Better Writing** – Understanding how professional writers structure ideas (topic sentence, supporting details, conclusion) improves your own writing.
6. **Exam Performance** – Comprehension carries significant marks (24 marks — the highest weightage among all Unit 1-5 topics per your syllabus’s Specification Table) since it tests multiple skills together (reading, vocabulary, writing) in one question.
7. **Effective Decision-Making** – In life, correctly understanding contracts, notices, forms, and instructions prevents misunderstandings.

Levels of Comprehension

Level	What it involves	Example question type
Literal	Understanding what is directly stated	“What did the author do first?”
Inferential	Reading between the lines; understanding implied meaning	“Why do you think the character felt that way?”
Critical/Evaluative	Judging the author’s argument, tone, or purpose	“Do you agree with the author’s viewpoint? Why?”
Applied	Connecting the passage to real-life situations	“How can this lesson apply to your own life?”

3.3 UNSEEN PASSAGES

An unseen passage is a **new passage you encounter for the first time during the exam or test**, requiring you to apply comprehension skills without prior preparation of the content itself.

Strategy to Solve Unseen Passages (Step-by-Step)

Step 1: Skim First - Quickly read the passage once to grasp the general topic and tone — don't focus on every word yet.

Step 2: Read the Questions Before the Second Read - Knowing what's being asked helps you read with purpose and locate answers faster.

Step 3: Read Carefully (Close Reading) - Read paragraph by paragraph, underlining/noting: - Key facts, names, numbers - Difficult words (guess meaning from context) - Topic sentences of each paragraph

Step 4: Answer in Your Own Words - Avoid copying full sentences verbatim unless asked for a direct quote; paraphrase to show understanding. - Keep answers concise and directly relevant to the question asked.

Step 5: Check Word/Mark Limits - If the question specifies a word limit (e.g., "in about 50 words"), stay close to it — examiners penalize both very short and overly long answers.

Step 6: Answer Vocabulary-in-Context Questions Carefully - When asked for a synonym/antonym or meaning of a word "as used in the passage," always refer back to the specific context — a word may have multiple meanings.

Step 7: Give the Passage a Title (if asked) - The title should be short, relevant, and capture the central theme.

Common Question Types in Unseen Passage Exercises

Question Type	What It Tests	Tip
Main idea / gist	Overall understanding	Look at first and last paragraphs
Factual/detail questions	Literal comprehension	Scan for keywords from the question
Vocabulary (synonym/antonym)	Word knowledge in context	Check surrounding sentences
Inference-based	Reading between lines	Consider tone and implied meaning
Title suggestion	Grasp of central theme	Keep it short and precise
Opinion/reflection	Critical thinking	Support your view with a reason from the passage

Common Mistakes to Avoid

- Answering from memory/assumption instead of the actual passage
- Copying entire paragraphs instead of answering precisely
- Ignoring word limits
- Misreading a "not" or negative word, reversing the intended

- meaning
 - Spending too much time on one question and rushing others
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3.4 INTERPRETATION OF PASSAGES IN WRITTEN AND SPOKEN FORM

Interpretation means going beyond literal reading to **explain, analyze, and express the meaning of a passage** — either by writing your understanding or by speaking about it (e.g., in a viva, presentation, or group discussion).

A. Written Interpretation

Key skills: 1. **Summarizing** - condensing the passage into its essential points in your own words, keeping the original meaning intact. 2. **Paraphrasing** - restating specific sentences/ideas in different words without changing the meaning. 3. **Answering analytically** - not just stating facts, but explaining “why” or “how” when asked (e.g., “Why did the author compare X to Y?”). 4. **Structuring your answer** - use a brief introduction (context), body (explanation with evidence from text), and conclusion (your interpretation/takeaway).

Example approach for a summary: > Read the passage → identify the main idea of each paragraph → combine these into 4-6 sentences → ensure it flows logically and covers beginning, middle, and end of the original passage.

B. Spoken Interpretation

Key skills: 1. **Clarity of expression** - speak in complete, grammatically correct sentences. 2. **Organized thought** - structure your spoken response just like a written one (introduction → main points → conclusion). 3. **Appropriate pace and tone** - neither too fast (hard to follow) nor too slow (loses listener’s attention). 4. **Use of transitional phrases** - “The passage mainly discusses...”, “According to the author...”, “This suggests that...”, “In conclusion...” 5. **Confidence and eye contact** - especially relevant when interpreting a passage aloud in a viva or oral exam (links to CO5 — presentation skills). 6. **Paraphrasing on the spot** - ability to explain a passage’s meaning without reading directly from it, showing genuine understanding rather than memorization.

Written vs Spoken Interpretation — Comparison

Feature	Written Interpretation	Spoken Interpretation
Time to think	More time to organize and revise	Requires quick thinking, less editing
Language	Formal, precise, grammatically polished	Can be slightly informal but still clear
Support tools	Can refer back to text while writing	Often requires memory/notes only
Delivery	Judged on structure, vocabulary, grammar	Judged on fluency, clarity, tone, body language
Best practice	Draft, revise, proofread	Practice aloud, use pauses effectively

Quick Revision Summary

Topic	Core Idea	Skill Developed
Seen Passages (MSBTE Workbook)	Six prescribed passages for detailed study	Focused reading & retention
Importance of Comprehension	Why reading comprehension matters academically & professionally	Awareness of comprehension's real-world value
Unseen Passages	Passages encountered without prior preparation	Applied reading strategy under time constraints
Interpretation (Written & Spoken)	Explaining passage meaning in your own words	Summarizing, paraphrasing, articulate expression

Aligned to CO3: "Comprehend passages correctly" and TLOs 3.1–3.4 as per MSBTE syllabus.